18.7 Cross-domain delegation among agents

Delegation becomes more complex when it crosses organizational boundaries. The model described in the previous section assumes a shared policy environment in which every request is evaluated by the same policy engine, using common enforcement points and governance processes. Within ACME, this allows delegation to be tightly controlled and consistently enforced. But when authority moves between organizations, that shared control is lost. The delegating system cannot directly enforce how the receiving agent acts.

Situations like this illustrate the idea that I call a *society of agents*. A society of agents does not emerge simply because agents interact. It emerges when shared rules, protocols, and governance mechanisms allow independent systems to cooperate reliably.

ACME faced this situation when the finance team started preparing to launch a new service to automate reimbursements for small contractors. The team wanted to use an AI assistant to help review routine reimbursement requests and initiate payments through a financial partner that provided a payment-agent service.